

Programme Review 2025

Internal memorandum - not for external circulation

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To	Dr. Lan Phuong Nguyen, Executive Director
From	Hung Vo, Programmes Director
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Subject	Honest review of 2025 delivery ahead of the Board strategy session
Classification	Internal - candid; please do not forward

Lan, ahead of the January strategy session you asked me for a frank picture rather than the version we put in front of donors. Here it is.

1. Dong Nai is in trouble

The Dong Nai hub is our weakest performer and the gap is widening. Internship drop-out reached 38 per cent last quarter against an organisation-wide average of 22 per cent. Two causes stand out. First, transport: young people are commuting 25 to 40 kilometres to industrial-zone placements and paying VND 150,000 to 200,000 a month in bus fares that we do not subsidise. Second, employer behaviour: several partners treat interns as free labour, with long hours and no clear duties. I have not shared the full Dong Nai numbers with VPBank.

2. Pathway Digital is being reported too generously

The completion rate we reported to the donor was 68 per cent. The true figure, measured as completers divided by those who actually started, is 52 per cent. The digital team used enrolments as the denominator. We need to correct this before it becomes a reputational problem.

3. The Long An pilot has not worked

Drop-out in the Long An pilot is around 60 per cent. The catchment is thinner than we assumed and we do not have enough local employers. I would not expand there until the model is fixed elsewhere.

4. Our people are stretched

Field staff turnover was 34 per cent this year. The team is doing heroic work, but it is not sustainable, and every departure costs us employer relationships that took years to build.

Recommendation

Before we promise anyone growth, we should fix Dong Nai, correct our reporting, and invest in the quality of our employer partnerships. Scaling a broken internship experience multiplies harm for the young people least able to absorb it. I know this is not the story Development wants to tell. It is the true one.

Hung